

Figure 8. View from the courtyard of the Dom Raja's home in Varanasi

In a mythological story—a cringe-inducing morality tale—that appears in *Markandeya Purana*, Raja Harishchandra is tested by the gods for his honesty and dharmic commitments. When demanded by a devious Brahmin stranger, the 'righteous' raja donates his entire kingdom to him because a virtuous king can't refuse a Brahmin. But the Brahmin wants more. So Harishchandra, a dharmic man, sells his wife and son into slavery, then sells himself to Kallu Dom to pay the Brahmin with the proceeds. The royals suffer greatly, their son dies, but Harishchandra persists with his absurd dharma, until the gods are fully satisfied and grant him an eternal place in heaven, taking Kallu Dom along too.

This story may have charmed my ancestors, but I find nothing admirable in it. It upholds an unthinking devotion to dharma and the caste order. Instead of punishing Harishchandra for his bad judgement and inhumanity towards his wife and son, the gods grant him moksha and sing his praises for respecting a Brahmin at all costs (so hard to guess who might have written this story!). Yet today, a temple to Harishchandra stands on the cremation ghat named after him. This story is a great source of pride and honour for the Doms. Kallu Dom was a raja, the Doms argue, because only